



Notification Waiver Determination

Cinven and La Caisse – Optio Group

Acquisition	Cinven Strategic Fund 2, which is indirectly managed and controlled by Cinven Limited (Cinven) as an alternative investment fund manager, and Caisse de dépôt et placement du Québec (La Caisse), via a special purpose vehicle, Welling Bidco Limited, applied for a notification waiver in respect of their proposed indirect acquisition of joint control of Spring Topco Limited, a company that indirectly owns the entire share capital of Optio Group Limited and its subsidiaries (together, Optio Group), as described in the transaction documents provided as part of the application (the Acquisition).
Determination	The Australian Competition and Consumer Commission has determined under section 51ABV(1)(a) of the <i>Competition and Consumer Act 2010</i> (Cth) that the Acquisition is not required to be notified.
Date of determination	17 September 2026

Parties to the Acquisition	Cinven is a private equity firm engaged in the provision of investment management and investment advisory services to a number of investment funds. The controlled companies in Cinven's portfolio of investments are active in a variety of sectors including business services, consumer, financial services, healthcare, industrials and technology, media, and telecommunications. La Caisse is a long-term institutional investor that manages funds of its depositors, primarily comprised of public and para-public pension and insurance plans in the Province of Québec, Canada. La Caisse is a global investment group which invests these funds globally in all major markets and asset classes, including public and private equity, fixed income, infrastructure, and real estate. The target, Optio Group, is an underwriting-led specialty Managing General Agent platform with an international footprint, headquartered in London and operating across the UK, Europe, the Middle East, North Africa, North America, and the Asia-Pacific. Optio Group also has an insurance brokerage arm. In Australia, both Optio Group and a portfolio company of La Caisse, Howden Group Holdings Limited, supply underwriting and management services to insurers and reinsurers as Managing General Agents (MGA services), and to a lesser extent, non-life insurance brokerage services.
Explanation for determination	In making this notification waiver determination, the Australian Competition and Consumer Commission (the ACCC) has considered the information provided with the notification waiver application and had regard to the factors in section 51ABV(2)(b) of the <i>Competition and Consumer Act 2010</i> (Cth) (the Act).

	Based on the information currently before it, the Acquisition is unlikely to give rise to any material lessening of competition given: a. the parties' combined shares of supply of MGA services and non-life insurance brokerage services in Australia are estimated to be low and the increments in share arising from the Acquisition are expected to be small b. there are alternative providers of MGA services and non-life insurance brokerage services in Australia. In these circumstances, the ACCC does not consider it necessary to reach a concluded view on the likelihood of the notification thresholds being met. Given that material competition concerns are unlikely to arise, the ACCC has determined that the Acquisition is not required to be notified. The ACCC considers that the determination is consistent with the object of the Act and the interests of consumers in promoting competition. For more information about the ACCC's approach to considering notification waiver applications and to assessing competition effects more generally, see the ACCC's guidance on notification waivers and merger assessment guidelines.
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**Determination made by Commissioner Williams pursuant to a delegation under section 25(1)
of the Act**